deepen India–China engagement in security and counter-terrorism. The two countries then signed a first-ever agreement on security cooperation to strengthen and consolidate assistance in counter-terrorism, organised crime, drug control, human trafficking, and exchange of information.[31]

These reciprocal moves show China's influence over Pakistan. In fact, even US National Security Advisor John Bolton has admitted that China enjoys stronger leverage than the United States in controlling the terror machine in Pakistan.[32] New Delhi cannot ignore this fact while dealing with Beijing on security.

The SCO has identified ISIS as a more serious threat to regional security than the Taliban. In fact, Pakistan, China, Russia, and Iran have all expressed more concern about the emergence of ISIS in their neighbourhood. In 2015, China adopted a law allowing military deployment overseas on anti-terror missions, and even though the possibility of Chinese forces joining Russian or other forces against ISIS remains unlikely, it illustrates the potential role of China in combating terrorism in the region and is something India has to factor into its regional calculus.

The Pakistan factor

The coordinated entry of India and Pakistan into a regional security body – the SCO – is being marketed as the SCO's key achievement, something even Washington has been unable to accomplish so far. Could their joint entry into the SCO prove to be a pivot for India–Pakistan entente? At the 2018 SCO Summit in Qingdao, China appeared very excited about India's and Pakistan's entry, and the Chinese believe that the SCO can be an ideal platform to turn the decades-old hostility between India and Pakistan into friendship.[33] A